front of Maa, I stopped mid-stride to see the two of them chatting. I was afraid she would tell Maa about what had happened in the morning.

‘Oh, hello Gunjan, come, have a seat,’ Ms Meenakshi said on seeing me.

‘Good . . . good evening, Ma’am,’ I said as I half-heartedly pulled out my chair. Maa’s keen eyes noticed my unease. ‘Something wrong, beta? Is the food not to your liking?’ she asked. I gave her a fake smile.

‘Oh, I think I know what could be troubling your daughter,’ Ms Meenakshi said at once. ‘My presence must have reminded her of her homework notebook. Any child would be troubled if their hard work were eaten by a dog.’ Then she turned to me. ‘Don’t worry Gunjan, if the stationer is taking time to bind the notebook, you can bring it on Tuesday.’ Ms Meenakshi got busy with her food after having unknowingly thrown this bomb at me. A confused Maa stared at me and I tried to look away. She had an inkling that I was hiding something. But she chose to wait until dinner was over. All that while, I hoped for a miracle to happen. But my fate was sealed.

Maa motioned to me to meet her outside the ante room when dinner was over. She needed and explanation, and I needed an escape route. ‘Did you lie to her?’ she asked me as we both stood outside under a streetlight on the pathway leading to the ante room. The sound of crickets chirping filled the air. She had her arms folded, a mark of her seriousness. ‘It’s nothing you cannot take care of, Maa,’ I replied, trying to sound casual and carefree.

‘Beauty doesn’t go near notebooks. You haven’t done your homework, right?’ she asked. Her expression was flat, or else I could have gauged her mood. ‘I don’t like social science, Maa. I don’t want to study the subject. Besides, I know you can find a way and get me excused,’ I tried to reason with her.

‘You thought I would help you get away with it? Is that why you didn’t do your homework?’ she asked slowly, yet firmly.

‘Of course,’ I replied rather casually. ‘There should be some perks of having my mother in the same school, right? Now, can we go inside? I don’t want to miss the episode.’